



The Giant Forest

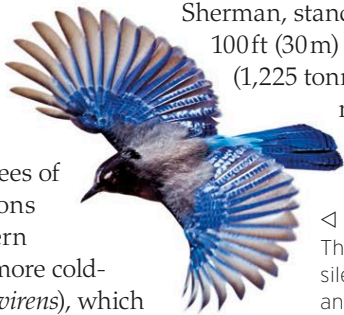
An ancient, sky-scraping forest of more than 8,000 giant sequoias, home to half of the largest and longest-lived trees on Earth

Growing at the heart of central California's Sequoia National Park, in the southern Sierra Nevada mountains, the Giant Forest is home to more than 8,000 giant sequoias (*Sequoiadendron giganteum*). While they may not be the world's tallest trees, they are easily the largest by volume.

A tale of two redwoods

Giant sequoias are often called redwoods and vice versa, but while both species are native to California and share similar cinnamon-colored bark and heady heights, they are decidedly different. The trees of the Giant Forest generally grow at elevations of 4,900–6,900 ft (1,500–2,100 m) on western Sierra Nevada slopes, making them much more cold-hardy than coast redwoods (*Sequoia sempervirens*), which

grow at lower coastal elevations. Giant sequoias live for around 3,000 years (as opposed to the redwoods' 2,000), and their bark is up to 2 ft (60 cm) thick. Sequoias do not grow as tall as redwoods—the maximum is around 310 ft (95 m) compared to the redwoods' 380 ft (115 m)—but what they lack in height is made up for in girth. The largest tree in the world, the Giant Forest's General Sherman, stands just 275 ft (84 m) high but is more than 100 ft (30 m) wide and weighs an estimated 1,350 tons (1,225 tonnes). At 52,513 cubic feet (1,487 cubic meters), it is the single largest living organism by volume in the world.



◁ OPPORTUNISTIC SCAVENGER

The Steller's jay's raucous call often breaks the silence of the Giant Forest. Omnivorous, jays eat anything from seeds and nuts to hikers' leftovers.

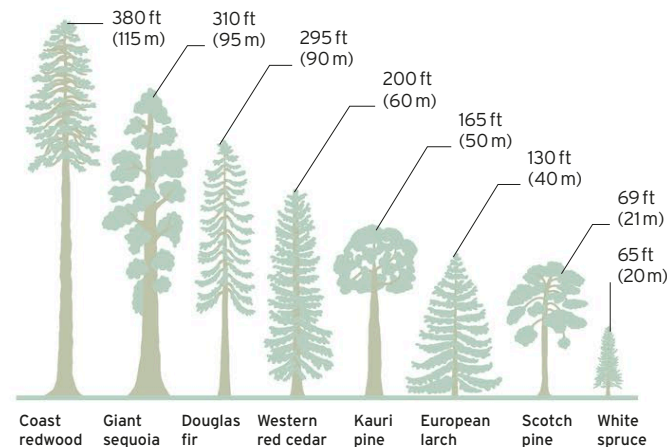
The high tannin content in giant sequoia bark prevents rotting

▷ MAMMOTH PROPORTIONS

The President is 245 ft (75 m) tall, making the scientists shown with it antlike by comparison.

CONIFER HEIGHTS

Because they lack the spread of deciduous trees, conifers grow much taller than the latter, but their heights vary greatly according to species. Coast redwoods are the tallest trees on Earth.



△ SHADE TOLERANT

Although the trees of the Giant Forest cast giant shadows, small trees such as the Pacific dogwood survive well in their shade.

